



BOARD TOOL

The Board Advancement Role Guide

How board members strengthen advancement through relationships and leadership, without vague fundraising pressure.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Connectors

Open doors to people who'd care if they understood.

Thankers

Help donors hear gratitude from leadership.

Hosts

Bring people closer through tables and tours.

Accountability

Make sure the follow-through actually happens.

1

THE PROBLEM

Why board advancement gets awkward

Board members are often told they need to "help with fundraising" without being given a clear role, a clear message, or a realistic way to participate. That creates guilt, avoidance, and uneven participation, where a few members make asks and the rest quietly step back. Most of them aren't refusing the mission. They're reacting to the fact that nobody ever told them what helping is supposed to look like.

A stronger approach defines board advancement as relationship support: some members make direct asks, while many open doors, thank donors, host conversations, invite people to events, review strategy, or carry the mission story with credibility.

BETTER BOARD FRAMING

Not every board member needs to become a fundraiser. What the organization needs is for each member to understand how their relationships, credibility, and leadership can strengthen the advancement system.

INSTEAD OF SAYING	SAY THIS INSTEAD	WHY IT WORKS BETTER
"We need everyone to fundraise."	"We need every board member to choose a clear advancement role."	It creates ownership without forcing one narrow behavior.
"Go ask your friends for money."	"Help us connect the mission to people who'd care if they understood it."	It respects relationships and focuses on mission fit.
"Bring in sponsors."	"Help identify businesses that already care about students, families, community, or faith-based work."	It gives members a useful filter.
"Make thank-you calls if you can."	"Each member takes two stewardship touches after major campaigns or events."	It turns vague help into an accountable action.
"We need more donors."	"We need warmer relationships before the next ask."	It puts relationship quality ahead of pressure.

2

THE ROLES

Five board advancement roles

Ask each member to pick two primary roles and one backup. Five roles cover the ways a board can move advancement forward, and only one of them involves making an ask.



ADVANCEMENT ROLE

Connector

Best for: Members with broad community, business, church, school, or civic relationships.

They can: Make warm introductions, invite guests to events, connect staff with potential sponsors, identify aligned businesses.

Not responsible for: Writing campaign strategy or making every ask personally.



ADVANCEMENT ROLE

Thanker

Best for: Members who are relational, gracious, and consistent.

They can: Call donors, write notes, thank sponsors, follow up with volunteers, recognize first-time givers.

Not responsible for: Defending budget details or answering technical gift questions.



ADVANCEMENT ROLE

Host

Best for: Members comfortable gathering people.

They can: Host a table, invite friends to campus, organize a small mission breakfast, bring prospects to events.

Not responsible for: Turning every gathering into a hard ask.



ADVANCEMENT ROLE

Story carrier

Best for: Members who can explain the mission clearly.

They can: Share the mission message, speak briefly at events, tell a student, family, ministry, or community story.

Not responsible for: Creating all marketing copy or over-polishing the message.



ADVANCEMENT ROLE

Accountability partner

Best for: Members with governance, finance, operations, or strategy strength.

They can: Review metrics, ask whether stewardship happened, check board follow-through, protect the annual rhythm.

Not responsible for: Micromanaging staff or owning daily execution.

3

WHO DOES WHAT

The staff and board division of labor

Board members can strengthen the advancement system, but they shouldn't become the system. A staff member, advancement lead, executive leader, or consultant quarterbacks the calendar, assignments, data, and follow-through. The board provides leadership, access, credibility, accountability, and personal touches.

THE ADVANCEMENT LEAD OWNS

Campaign calendar, donor segmentation, CRM updates, gift tracking, sponsor materials, event logistics, thank-you tracking, tax letters, appeal drafts, and reporting.

THE BOARD SUPPORTS

Introductions, table hosting, thank-you calls, sponsor relationships, mission storytelling, strategic review, accountability, and leadership participation.

THE PRINCIPLE

The board strengthens the system. It doesn't replace the person who runs it. Clear ownership is what keeps board energy from turning into confusion.

4

THE MENU

The board role menu

This is the heart of the guide. Ask each member to choose two primary roles and one backup, then assign concrete actions. A check marks the role each action belongs to.

ACTION	CONNECTOR	THANKER	HOST	STORY	ACCOUNTABILITY
Make two warm introductions per quarter	☑				
Call three donors after major events		☑			
Write five thank-you notes after the year-end campaign		☑			
Invite two guests to a tour or event	☑		☑		
Host a small gathering once per year			☑		
Share a mission story at a donor or board meeting				☑	
Help review the campaign message for clarity				☑	
Review the retention and stewardship dashboard quarterly					☑
Ask whether follow-up happened after gifts and events					☑
Identify five businesses or partners that fit the mission	☑				

Meet one-on-one to confirm each member's roles. A menu people choose from beats a mandate handed down, and it gives leadership a practical way to assign work.

5

CADENCE

The quarterly board rhythm

Board advancement works when it has a rhythm. Put one advancement item on every quarter's agenda and the work stays visible.

QTR	BOARD FOCUS	MEETING AGENDA ITEM	MEMBER ACTION
Q1	Set priorities and identify relationships.	Review the annual calendar, donor retention, lapsed donors, and top relationship gaps.	Choose roles, submit names, schedule introductions.
Q2	Support the spring event and close the stewardship loop.	Review the event plan, sponsor needs, board assignments, and the post-event thank-you list.	Host, invite, thank, and report relationship notes.
Q3	Cultivate before year-end.	Review impact proof, the sponsor pipeline, and donor-visit opportunities.	Invite guests, open doors, carry stories.
Q4	Year-end campaign and donor renewal.	Review the appeal message, board participation, major-donor touches, and the stewardship plan.	Lead by example, make personal touches, support renewal.

6 MEASUREMENT

Lead measures for board participation

Board participation should be measurable without reducing members to salespeople. Track specific relationship actions, then watch whether they strengthen retention, sponsor renewal, and new relationships.

LEAD MEASURE	SIMPLE TARGET	LAG MEASURE IT SUPPORTS
Warm introductions	Each connector provides two per quarter.	New prospects, sponsor opportunities, donor visits.
Thank-you calls	Each thanker makes two or three after major campaigns or events.	Donor retention, donor satisfaction, renewal likelihood.
Hosted invitations	Each host invites two people to one event or tour per year.	New donor acquisition, prospect qualification.
Mission stories carried	Each story carrier shares one current story per quarter.	Message consistency, cultivation, community awareness.
Stewardship accountability	The board reviews follow-up completion quarterly.	Closed-loop stewardship and fewer dropped relationships.

7

LEADING BY EXAMPLE

Giving comes first

There's one financial expectation worth naming plainly, and it sits apart from everything else in this guide. Before a board member chooses a role, the board gives.

Personal giving and a relationship role are two separate commitments. Every member gives at a level that's meaningful to them, whatever that number is. Then every member chooses how they'll help advance the mission. The amount stays private. The participation is what matters, and the practical target is full board participation in giving.

This expectation strengthens the no-pressure approach rather than working against it. A board that gives can invite others with credibility, because it's asking people to join something its own members have already done. Funders and major donors notice, too. Many will ask whether the full board gives before they make a significant commitment of their own.

TWO DIFFERENT ASKS

Give, then choose a role. Giving at a meaningful level is the one financial expectation. Choosing a role is how each member helps beyond their own gift. Neither one requires becoming a professional fundraiser.

New in this edition. Board giving is a near-universal best practice that the earlier guide didn't address, so we've added it here. If it doesn't fit your culture, this section lifts out cleanly.

8

COPY YOU CAN USE

Simple scripts board members can use

Most members don't avoid advancement because they don't care. They avoid it because they don't know what to say. Here's language they can borrow.

Warm introduction

When opening a door for a staff member

I thought of you because [Organization] is doing meaningful work with [students, families, community, ministry area], and your background in [business, community, education, faith, service] seems aligned. I'm not asking you for anything today. I'd just like to introduce you to [Name] so you can hear what they're building and decide whether it's worth learning more.

Thank-you call

When stewarding a recent gift

I'm calling as a board member just to say thank you. Your support of [campaign or event] helped make [specific impact] possible. We're grateful, and I wanted you to hear that from someone on the board, not only from a receipt or an email.

Event invitation

When bringing a guest closer

I'd like you to come as my guest to [Event]. It's a good way to understand the mission without pressure. You'll meet people involved, hear the story, and see why this work matters. If it feels like a fit afterward, we can talk about other ways to be involved.

Sponsor opener

When exploring a business partnership

We're looking for business partners who want to be visibly connected to work that strengthens [students, families, community, mission]. I thought of your company because [specific reason]. Would it be worth introducing you to the team so you can see whether this sponsorship makes sense?

9

ACTIVATION

Commitment and 90-day plan

Two tools to put this to work: a commitment each member fills out, and a 90-day plan to activate the board.

Board member commitment

My two primary advancement roles are:	
My backup advancement role is:	
Three people or businesses I could introduce are:	
One event, tour, or gathering I can help support is:	
Two stewardship touches I'll make after major events are:	
What I need from staff to do this well:	

90-day activation plan

- 1 Explain advancement as relationship support and have each board member choose two roles and one backup.
- 2 Build a simple relationship list from board members, staff, families, donors, alumni, congregations, and sponsors.
- 3 Assign one concrete action per member then review completed actions and next steps at the following board meeting.

PAIRS WITH

The **Waypoint Advancement Framework** shows where these board roles fit inside the full advancement system, and the **30-Day Post-Event Calendar** puts the thank-you and host roles to work right after an event.